

Visualizing Change in Sociological Theory

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May 10, 2023

This figure shows how frequently sociological theorists were cited in top sociology journals from 1895 until now. We observe a slow decline in the popularity of the classic trio (Weber, Durkheim, and Marx) since the 1990s, and the rise of Bourdieu from among the last group of general theorists (Bourdieu, Giddens, Habermas). As insets to the main figure, I present co-citation networks by decade. In these networks, we see how Bourdieu has displaced Parsons as one of the most central theorists in the field after Weber.

Claims about the popularity or lack thereof of a theorist are part of the discourse in handbooks, courses, and chatter between sociologists. For instance, Parsons famously began *The Structure of Social Action* rhetorically asking “who now reads Spencer?” [Parsons, 1937]. Decades later, others wondered “who now reads Parsons?” [Bryant, 1983]. Yet, that was only a few years before Jeffrey Alexander would claim that “with the exception of Habermas, no post-classical sociological theorist is more talked about today

in Europe and the United States than Parsons himself” [Alexander, 1988]. Disagreements are understandable, as these claims are contingent on the authors’ position. They are also strategic, a segue into a more important point the author wants to make about changes in the field. Because acquiring a sense of the who’s who of sociological theory is still an important aspect of the socialization of new sociologists I offer here a new perspective. for that purpose, I use citation counts for some classical and modern sociological theorists starting with the foundation of the American Journal of Sociology in 1885 to the present date.

Without any pretension to define boundaries in the canon of sociological theory, I take a set of authors that frequently appear in classical and modern sociological theory courses. Karl Marx, Emile Durkheim, Max Weber, and W.E.B Du Bois as classical theorists. Robert K. Merton and Talcott Parsons are included as representatives of the generation that helped establish a canon in sociological theory [Joas and Knöbl, 2009]. Lastly, I include Pierre Bourdieu, Anthony Giddens, and Jürgen Habermas as members of the last generation of sociological theorists who developed general theoretical systems. The data contains all articles (including book reviews) published in the American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, Sociological Theory, and Social Forces. Because these journals were founded in different years¹ the composition changes over time. I present total and not relative counts so the trends can be read as representing both the change in popularity of these authors as well as the growth of the discipline over the twentieth century. All the code and data (collected from Google Scholar) are available in a public repository (link not included for anonymity).

The popularity of the classic trio (Weber, Durkheim, Marx) grew in parallel to that of those who helped establish them as central figures in sociol-

¹The American Journal of Sociology was founded in 1885, Social Forces in 1922, American Sociological Review in 1936, and Sociological Theory in 1983.

ogy. Nevertheless, the number of citations of these classic authors went down slower than that of Merton and Parsons. Of the three, Weber is now the most cited. Du Bois, who was four years younger than Weber, only became widely cited after the turn of the millennium, and he is now almost as often cited as Durkheim. In the case of Bourdieu, Giddens, and Habermas we can see how these three authors, who position themselves as general theorists in the '80s, had remarkably similar trends at the time, but whilst Bourdieu's popularity kept growing and eventually surpassed Parsons in the '90s, Habermas and Giddens slowly lost their share.

Bourdieu not only became highly cited but also took over Parsons' central role in the co-citation network of theorists (figure insets). Parsons was the most central node in the '50s, '60s, and '70s, a role that was taken over by Weber who has been the most central node ever since. By the '2010s Bourdieu had displaced Parsons as the contemporary author at the core of the network, standing next to Weber ².

²Being a weighted network, the position of the nodes depends on the strength of their ties to other nodes (which is the number of articles in which two authors are cited together). Thus, the position of a node is dependent on the author's popularity, although it does not result directly from it. For instance, although Du Bois was frequently cited during the '2010s he was the least central node in the network.

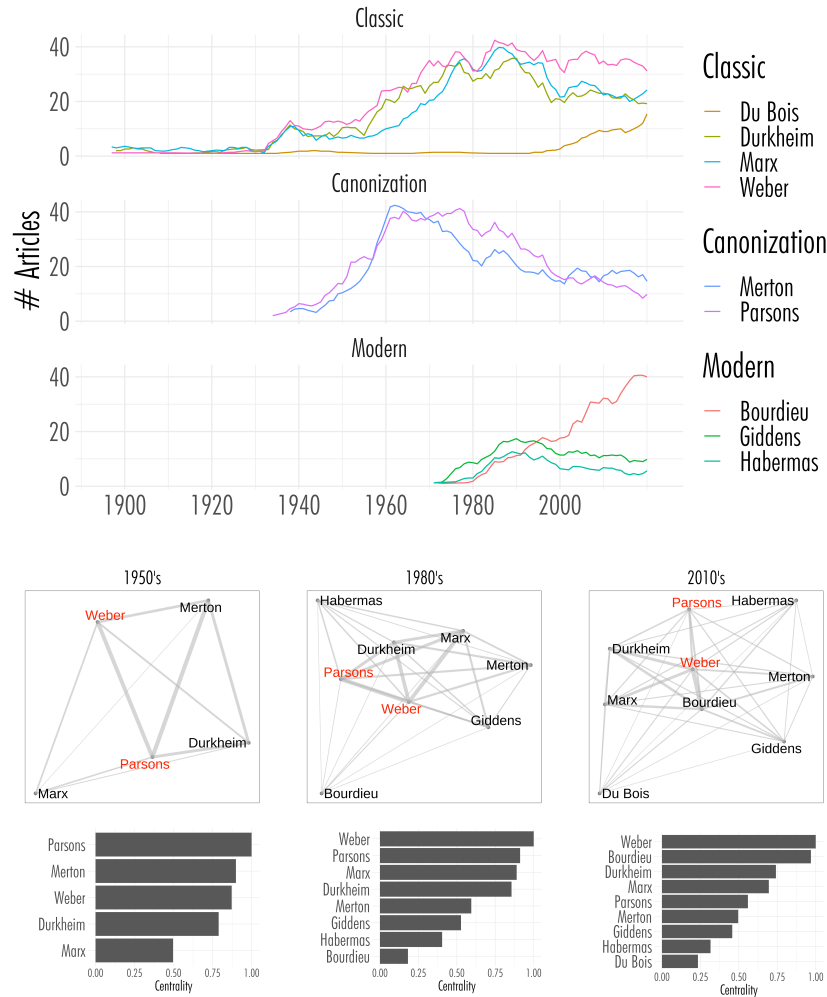


Figure 1: Number of citations of sociological theorists over time. Includes all articles published in the American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, Sociological Theory, and Social Forces since their foundation. The y-axis represents the moving average of the number of articles citing an author published in a given year. Sliding window of 4 years. **Bottom insets represent co-citation networks of selected decades and eigenvector centrality measures.** The width of the tie between two nodes corresponds to the number of articles citing both authors. Authors with less than 10 citations in a decade are excluded.

References

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